



Akula, Ayhika Mukherjee, and a not-fully-fit Diya Chitale. The 3-0 triumph over Tamil Nadu underlined its supremacy.

Petroleum men, without Sharath, chose to rest an in-form Harmeet for the final and fielded a struggling duo of A. Amalraj and Manav Thakkar in the company of Sathiyar, whose only appearance came in the title clash against Delhi. The eventual 3-0 result was much anticipated.

In the open event, the acceptance of Manika's last-minute entry exposed the double standards of the TTFI. After the draw was made, Manika's call to Competition Manager N. Ganeshan, followed by an email from the Petroleum Sports Promotion Board, proved enough. Fearing pressure from those in authority in Indian sports, it was decided to quietly accommodate Manika and make necessary changes to the singles draw.

The players, coaches, and parents present, in private, questioned TTFI for flouting its own rules. However, they were all aware of the clout Manika wields after winning a legal battle and bringing TTFI to its knees in 2022. However, Manika was sent packing following her first outing. Manika, who had received a first-round bye, ran into Haryana's

Bengal import, Prithoki Chakraborty, this time and fell in just 33 minutes. Prithoki's 11-7, 4-11, 12-10, 8-11, 11-8 triumph remained the talking point of the evening, though men's second seed Manav Thakkar also made his exit.

Thakkar, who lost a couple of matches in the team championship, paid the price for his inconsistency against 15th seed Anirban Ghosh, who emerged as a surprise 11-6, 9-11, 11-3, 6-11, 11-5 winner.

Though upsets continued, how a scrappy Sharath survived Delhi youngster Yashansh Malik in the pre-quarterfinal was an indication of the 10-time winner not being anywhere close to his peak form.

The following morning, left-hander Manush Shah proved more than a handful for fourth-seeded Sharath. He chalked out an almost unbelievable scoreline of 11-9, 11-1, 11-4, 11-4 in what appeared to be the great champion's last appearance in the national championship.

Eventually, the much-anticipated final between Harmeet and Sathiyar proved to be a fitting finale. Both players gave it their all in seven pulsating games. Sathiyar, nursing a troubled back, took a medical time-out after trailing 2-3 and came

back to force the decider, but Harmeet was not to be denied another success.

In the women's section, Poymantee's amazing run will be recalled for a long time. Not among the top eight seeds, Poymantee took out former champion Archana Kamath in the quarterfinals, defending champion Sreeja in the semifinals, and then bounced back to trump Ayhika in the final.

Coming from a modest background, Poymantee showed how desperately she needed the national title. Poymantee's attitude, that of a gutsy street fighter, stood out on the big points. Coached by Abhishek Mukherjee, this 21-year-old Railway player showed tremendous fighting spirit and scant respect for reputations. One hopes Poymantee gets her due and more opportunities to polish her skill sets. Before signing off her campaign with the singles title, Poymantee collected the team bronze, won the doubles gold with Sutirtha Mukherjee, and finished runner-up in the mixed doubles final with Akash Pal. Notably, the Akash-Poymantee combination swept four national ranking titles this year. But the singles gold brought the biggest joy to Poymantee during a fantastic 2023.